Media, Public Interest & Inflation in Germany (2022-2024)

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11.6% — **Peak Inflation** (Oct 2022)

141.2 — **Max. Energy Index** (Shock Phase)

566 — **News Articles** (Peak Monthly Volume)

3.1% — **Avg. Unemployment** (Highly Stable)

1. Abstract & Methodology

This study investigates the transmission mechanisms between macroeconomic indicators and public economic anxiety in Germany (2022–2024). Utilizing high-frequency search data (**Google Trends**), news volume (**GDELT**), and official indices (**Destatis**), we assess whether public sentiment is driven by objective financial burdens or amplified by media salience.

2. Structural Breaks: The 5% Threshold

Time-series data reveals a pronounced, non-linear threshold effect in public behavior. Empirical evidence demonstrates that search volumes exhibit massive structural breaks exclusively during periods where the core inflation rate exceeds the 5% margin.

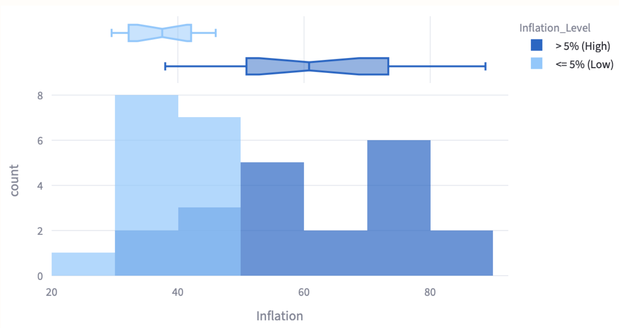

Figure 1: Search volume distribution segmented by the 5% threshold.

Subsequent to disinflation below this psychological boundary (e.g., throughout 2024), macroeconomic anxiety dissipates almost entirely.

Executive Conclusion

The 2022-2024 economic crisis was predominantly a **"price and media" phenomenon**. Public anxiety exhibits high elasticity to media narratives and acute energy volatility, but profound inelasticity to prolonged food inflation and stable labor markets.

→ Economic crises in the public consciousness are as much psychological as they are mathematical.

Data Repository & Live Application

https://data-science-projekt-2026.streamlit.app

References:

- Destatis (2024): CPI, Energy/Food, Labour.
- Google Trends (2024): SVI.
- GDELT Project (2024).

3. Media-Driven Attention Dynamics & Spillovers

Empirical evidence demonstrates a profound synchronization between media reporting volume and search interest. Furthermore, an autoregressive lagged effect indicates that media saturation in period t serves as a robust leading indicator for public anxiety in period $t+1$, establishing the media as the primary catalyst for economic panic.

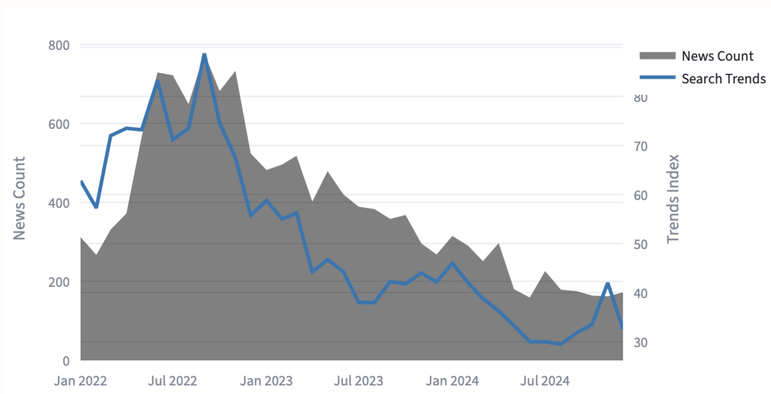

Figure 2: News Volume perfectly shadows Search Trends.

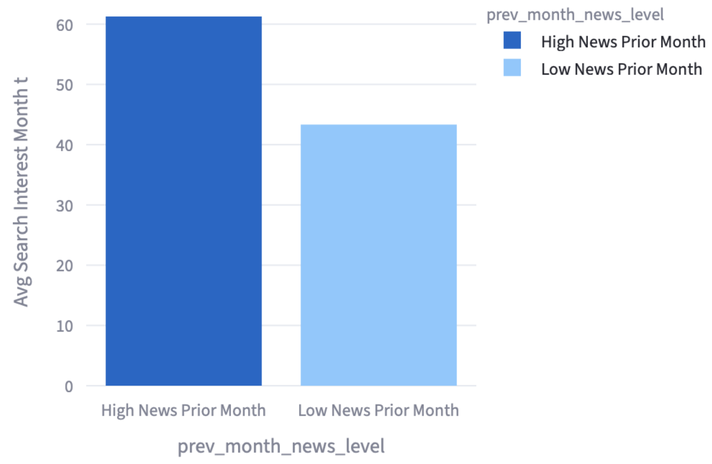

Figure 3: Lagged Spillover: Prior month's news vs. anxiety.

4. Asymmetric Habituation: Energy vs. Food

We identify a stark asymmetry in the public's response based on the specific inflation vector. High-volatility exogenous shocks (**Energy Prices**) act as acute triggers, yielding synchronous panic responses. Conversely, prolonged monotonic price increases (**Food Prices**) induce a significant **psychological habituation effect**, decoupling living costs from public concern over time.

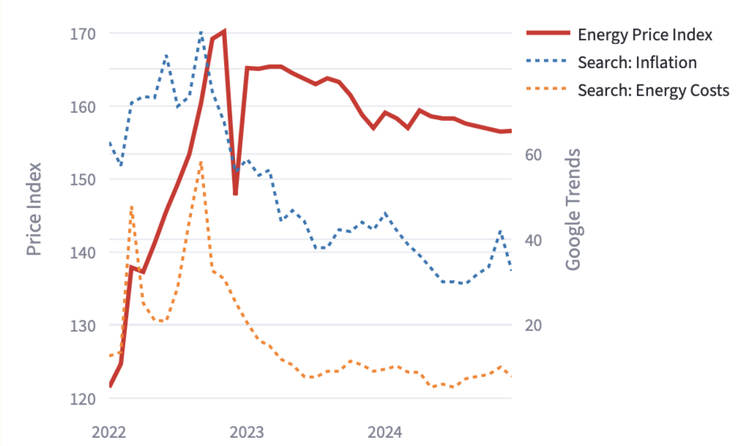

Figure 4: Energy Price Volatility vs. Synchronous Panic.

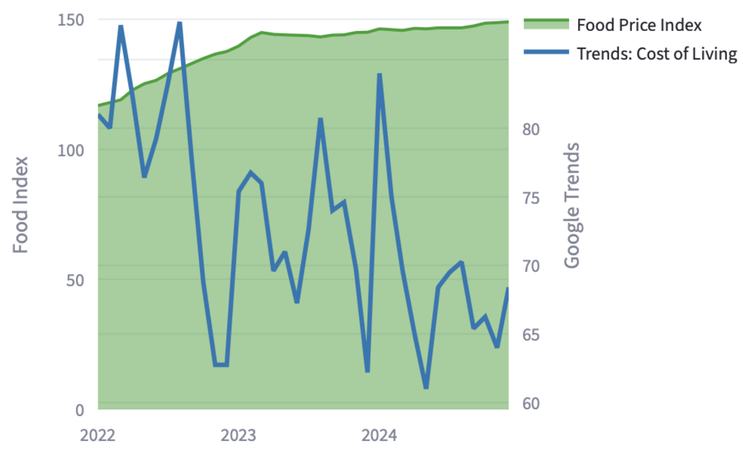

Figure 5: Habituation despite relentlessly rising Food Prices.

5. Multivariate Interactions & Trajectories

Cross-sectional analysis confirms that energy prices and news volume exhibit the highest collinearity with public panic, while the labor market remains structurally insulated. While public interest tracks inflation during the escalation phase (2022), the subsequent decay phase highlights that public sentiment normalizes significantly faster than inflation itself.

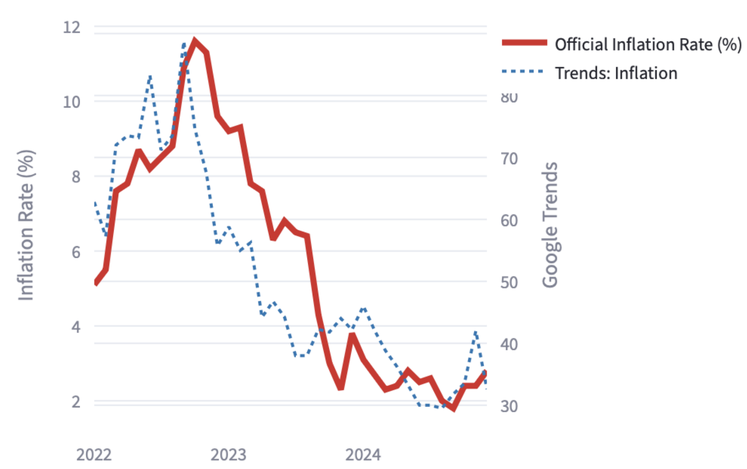

Figure 6: Trajectory Divergence: Official Inflation vs. Trend Decay.

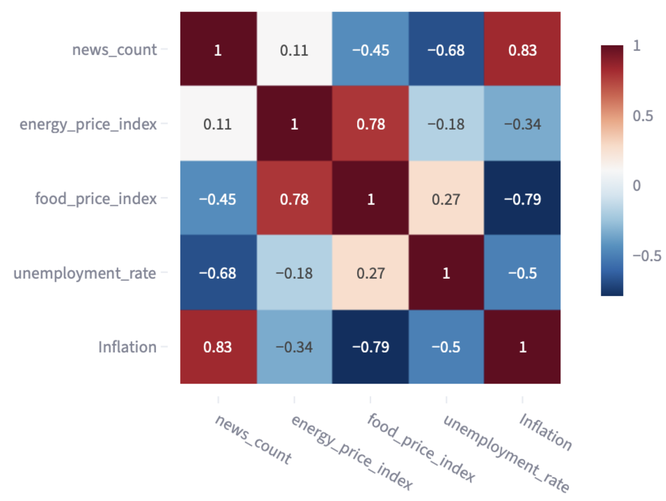

Figure 7: Correlation Matrix: Macro indicators vs. Media/Trends.